

core group for much of the past decade, he was third in line behind the legendary P. R. Sreejesh and Krishan Pathak. With only two goalkeeper spots in an 18-member international squad — and just one at the Olympics — Karkera was often sidelined during major tournaments. His rare opportunities came only when Sreejesh was injured or rested.

"The waiting period has been hard," Karkera tells *Sportstar*. "Not being able to play, when all I've ever dreamt of is playing for my country and winning medals. It really puts your character to the test. You find out what you're made of when things aren't going your way. These are testing times, and you have to rely on patience and resilience to get through them."

When Sreejesh retired after the Paris Olympics, most assumed Pathak would inherit the mantle. Instead, it was Karkera who seized the

moment, rising to prominence during the 2024–25 FIH Pro League.

On a disappointing European tour where India managed just one win in eight matches, his performances stood out. Questions lingered over the goalkeeping unit's handling of aerial balls, but the Mumbai-born custodian was among the few bright spots. Now, as he prepares for the Hockey Asia Cup in Rajgir, he is focused on the future.

"There are no grey areas; it is either black or white. Hockey is a result-oriented game, and we fell short. Yes, we are aware of our mistakes, and we are working hard to improve," he says.

Goalkeeper rivalries: A myth?

For many, goalkeeping is seen as a cutthroat rivalry, with teammates fighting for the coveted top spot. Karkera insists the reality is different. He describes the unit, now comprising Pathak, Pawan Malik, and himself, as a



TITLES WON

Asia Cup

2022 Jakarta — Bronze

Asian Champions Trophy

2024 Hulunbuir — Gold

2021 Dhaka — Bronze

Individual Award

Goalkeeper of the Tournament — Asian Champions Trophy 2021

close-knit group built on camaraderie and healthy competition.

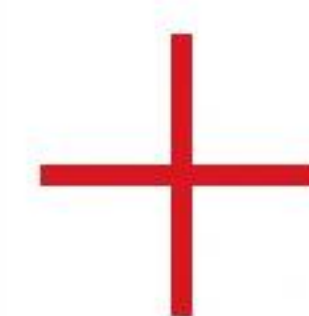
"From outside it may look different, but from where we are, it [competition for the place] is what makes us so strong," he explains. "We push each other to become better, which ultimately makes the team stronger."

In modern hockey, he points out, a goalkeeper's role extends far beyond stopping shots. Agility, quick decision-making, and penalty corner defence are crucial. With shootouts now common, adaptability is vital.

For Karkera, the goalkeeper is more than a last line of defence. Positioned to see the entire field, he becomes the conductor of the defensive orchestra, directing play and organising during counterattacks. As he puts it, "the priority is always clear: control the defence, control the game."

Finding inspirations and influences

Ironically, his path to hockey began not with the stick and ball but with the imposing gear of a goalkeeper. At his school, Children's Academy in Malad, he was drawn to the pads rather than the field players' flair. The fascination quickly turned into commitment, nurtured by legendary Mumbai coach Merzban 'Bawa' Patel and shaped further by



STATS

Senior International Caps — 66

First match — 09/08/2017

Latest match — 22/06/2025



PIC: HOCKEY INDIA